Challenge 3: New Caste Coalitions and the Problems of Expansion

This book has shown how the BJP's political growth was driven by a major expansion of its social base in the northern Hindi heartland, especially with OBCs. The Mehta–Singh Social Index demonstrated how the BJP shifted from being an upper caste-dominated party to becoming the most socially representative party by caste in UP.[65] These findings showed how our understanding of the BJP's caste representation has so far not kept pace with ground realities. OBCs (mostly non-Yadav) made up exactly half of the party's MPs elected from general category seats nationwide in 2019. Similarly, the BJP also significantly upped SC (mostly non-Jatav) representation among its MPs, MLAs, state-level office-bearers and ministers. So much so that OBCs and SCs, taken together, came to occupy half or more than half the leadership positions at virtually every level of the party in UP—barring district presidents. This Mandalisation of the BJP was built on the forging of new caste coalitions that significantly increased the party's influence.

However, its current growth pattern also runs the risk of turning the BJP into a new Congress. In its heyday, the Congress was an umbrella group of multiple factions, interests and sections, many of them inimical to each other. Now that the BJP has supplanted the Congress as the country's dominant party with its new caste coalitions, it runs the same risk of internal tussles that the older party struggled with. Caste equations are not static, nor are castes monolithic. Smaller castes like Nishads or Rajbhars moved to the BJP because they were given greater representation, but sustaining this equation requires nimble political skills on both sides. Furthermore, for a party that has invested so much in accommodating defectors and giving them key positions in almost every state—from Himanta Biswa Sarma in Assam to Jyotiraditya Scindia in Madhya Pradesh—how the newcomers mesh with, and engage with, the core party faithful in the long term will be a crucial factor to watch.

Managing this mélange of interest groups will be a major challenge for a party that, until 2014, was comparatively